

FRENCH REVOLUTIONARY AND NAPOLEONIC INFANTRY

Infantrymen in the French Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars fought mainly with smoothbore flintlock muskets and bayonets, and most of them also carried a sword. Their white trousers and coat were complemented by a “shako”, or hat, complete with regimental badge and pompom. The infantry comprised fusilier companies fighting alongside grenadiers – the senior infantry regiment, who were particularly well kitted out – and, after 1805, *voltigeurs* (shorter soldiers who specialized in skirmishing and scouting). The troops of Napoleon’s “Grande Armée” were celebrated not only for their discipline, courage, and devotion, but also for their ornate uniforms.

▼ INFANTRYMAN’S SHAKO

Date 1806

Origin France

Material Felt, leather

The shako replaced the earlier bicorne hat of the French infantry in 1806. On this shako, the front plate bears the imperial eagle and the regimental number, as well as a tricolour cockade.



Red collar matches cuffs

Chinstrap

◀ GRENADEER OFFICER’S COAT

Date c.1810

Origin France

Material Wool, linen

This coat was worn by an officer in the Grenadier infantry in Napoleon’s Imperial Guard. French soldiers referred to the Imperial Guard as “the Immortals”. They had better equipment, rank, and quarters than their counterparts in the main army.



Blue collar

White flap on red cuff

► NAPOLEONIC INFANTRY UNIFORM

Date c.1810

Origin France

Material Wool, linen

The Napoleonic infantryman wore a dark blue tunic with white facings and a red collar and cuffs. The loose-fitting white trousers were worn over knee breeches. This uniform has corporal’s stripes.



▼ NAPOLEONIC INFANTRY SWORD

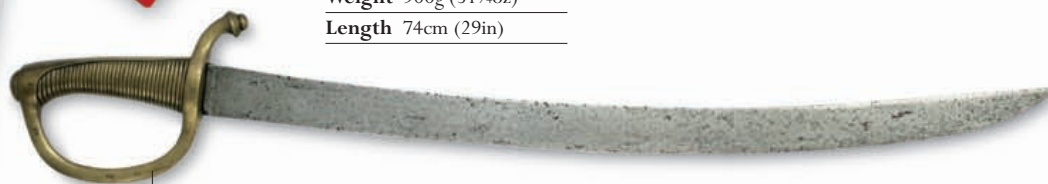
Date c.1800

Origin France

Weight 900g (31¼oz)

Length 74cm (29in)

The infantryman’s hanger, known as a “briquet”, had a simple, one-piece brass hilt and a curved steel blade. It was also issued to sailors.



Knuckle guard

▼ CHARLEVILLE MODÈLE 1777

Date 1777

Origin France

Weight 4.5kg (10lb)

Barrel 1.13m (3¾ft)

Calibre 17.5mm

The Modèle 1777 was one of a series of modifications to the French Charleville smoothbore flintlock musket, so-called because many were made at the Charleville armoury. This model was used by the infantry in the Revolutionary Wars. Infantrymen were expected to be able to fire three volleys a minute with this weapon.



Cock

Socket bayonet